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International Education and Living Costs Data Story

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Links

Data Source(s): [Kaggle Datasets](#)

Draft Dashboard: [Google Sheets Dashboard](#)

Final Data Story: [Tableau Public Dashboard](#)

Documentation: [Google Doc](#)

About the Data

This dataset contains information about the cost of education in different countries, with other information such as living costs, health insurance costs, tuition, and rent costs.

The data comes from a public Kaggle dataset, and the creator lists their sources below:

- Tuition Fees sourced from UNESCO and OECD's Education at a Glance reports.
- Living Cost Index based on Mercer's global surveys and verified with Numbeo data.
- Rent Prices aggregated from Mercer's housing data and Numbeo's student accommodation listings.
- Visa Fees taken from the U.S. Department of State's official visa fee schedules.
- Insurance Costs collected from ISO international student health insurance plans.
- Exchange Rates provided by the OANDA API for accurate USD conversions.

The data was collected in 2025, and is in CSV format.

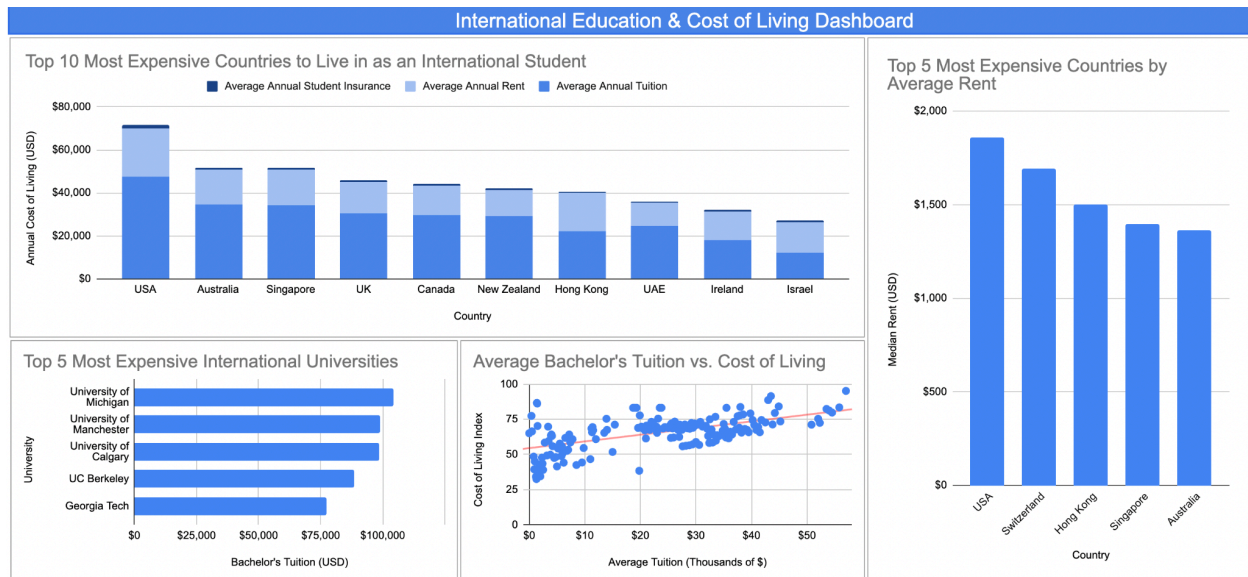
Columns used:

- Country: String, ISO country name where the university is located
- City: String, city where the university is located
- University: String, official university name
- Program: String, specific course of major (e.g., Computer Science)
- Level: String, degree level of the program (e.g., Undergraduate, Master's PhD)
- Tuition_USD: Numeric, total program tuition cost converted into USD, with values ranging from \$0–\$62,000
- Living_Cost_Index: Numeric, normalized index reflecting relative living expenses with New York City as the baseline (100), with values ranging from 27.8–122
- Rent_USD: Numeric, average monthly rent converted into USD, with values ranging from \$150–\$2,500
- Insurance_USD, Numeric, annual cost of health or student insurance (required by many host countries), converted into USD, with values ranging from \$200–\$1500

Data questions:

- Which universities internationally have the most expensive tuition?
- Do cities with a higher cost of living index also contain universities with higher tuition on average?
- What are the most expensive countries and cities to live in as an international student?

Draft Dashboard



Data Source: [Kaggle Dataset](#) (Same data)

Tool: Google Sheets

Description:

This dashboard breaks down the most expensive cities, countries, and universities to study in as an international student. I chose to make the total living costs by country the largest view here, followed by the most expensive countries by average rent, as students are likely going to consider their country of interest first and then narrow down universities from their chosen country. I also tried to make the chart types feel less redundant by alternating between bar/column graphs.

Findings:

The visualizations showcase that the United States is the most expensive country to study in across the board—it had the highest total living costs for international students as well as the highest rent, and the most expensive international universities were almost all in the United States. Additionally, the scatterplot revealed that there is a positive correlation between average annual bachelor's degree tuition and the cost of living for the city that the university is situated in.

Data Preparation



Major	Degree Level	Tuition_USD	Living_Cost_Index	Rent_USD	Rent_Annual_USD	Insurance
Computer Science	Master	8,900	51.2	800	9,600	400
Data Science	Master	8,500	51.2	750	9,000	400
Software Engineering	Master	7,800	48.9	700	8,400	400
Artificial Intelligence	Master	8,200	48.9	720	8,640	400
Computer Engineering	Master	7,500	45.3	550	6,600	400
Information Technology	Master	7,200	44.1	500	6,000	400
Computer Science	Master	6,900	43.8	480	5,760	400
Software Engineering	Master	6,500	41.2	450	5,400	400
Data Science	Master	6,300	40.5	420	5,040	400
Computer Engineering	Master	6,100	39.8	400	4,800	400
Artificial Intelligence	Master	8,200	58.4	800	9,600	400
Computer Engineering	Master	8,900	52.3	800	9,600	400
Finance	Bachelor	22,000	78.6	1,500	18,000	600
Artificial Intelligence	PhD	1,900	39.8	240	2,880	300
Computer Science	Master	1,600	40.5	250	3,000	300

Tool: Tableau Prep

Description:

When cleaning and preparing this data, I had to remove unnecessary columns, rename some confusing column titles, and create calculated fields for annual rent and total living costs. In my draft Google Sheets dashboard, I noticed that “Hong Kong” was listed as a country, resulting in it incorrectly being listed as one of the most expensive countries to live in as an international student. Later, when making my final draft of the Tableau version of the dashboard, I also noticed that MIT and Massachusetts were swapped (“MIT” was in the City column, and Massachusetts, in the “University” Column). I ensured that all cities and countries were listed correctly, and fixed the discrepancies with city, country, and university names.

Steps:

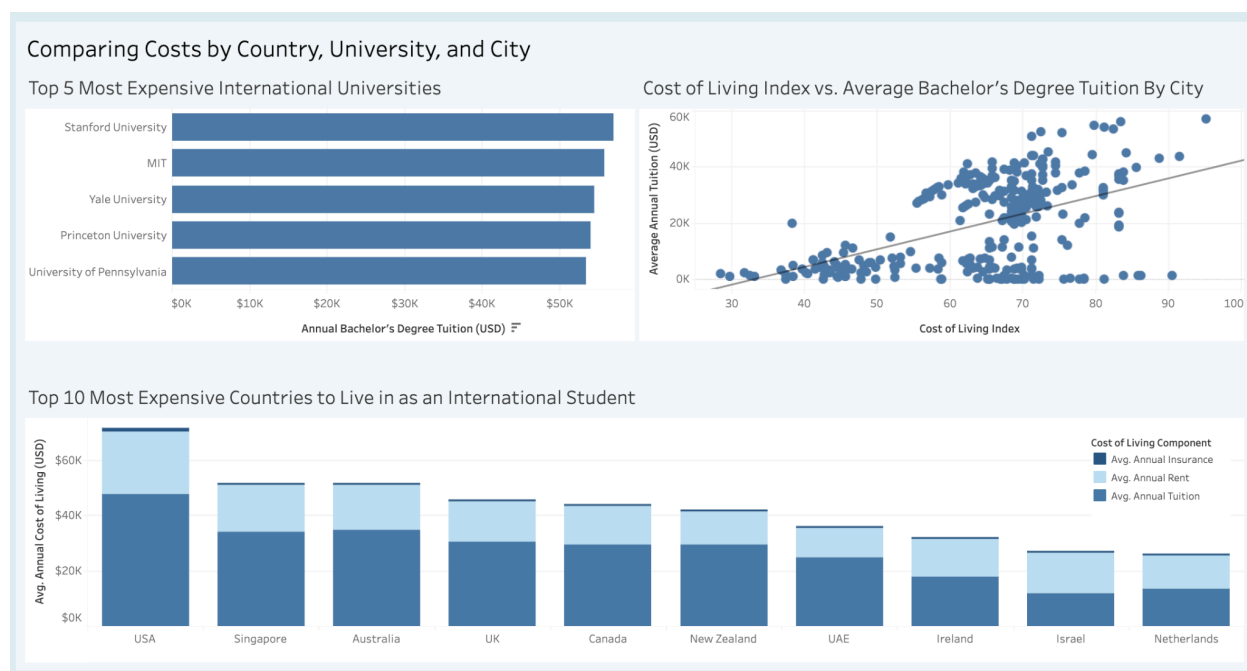
- Removed “Duration_Years”, “Exchange_Rate”, and “Visa_Fee” as they would not be used in the final dashboard
- Renamed “Program” to “Major”, “Level” to “Degree Level”, and “Rent_USD” to “Rent_Monthly_USD”
- Created calculated field for annual rent using the monthly rent column

- Created calculated field for total annual cost of living using annual, rent, tuition, and insurance
- Fixed “Hong Kong” data point and rename to “China”
- Fixed Massachusetts/MIT swap

Data Story

Tool: Tableau Desktop

Multi-View Dashboard



Description:

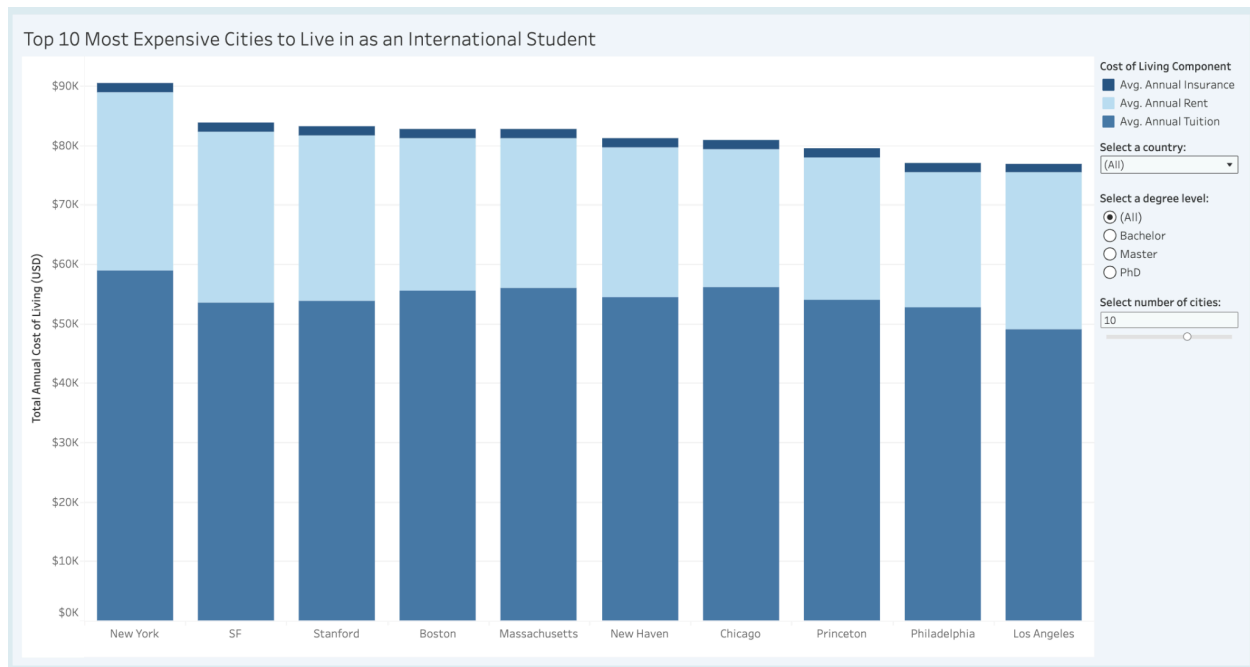
Similar to the draft dashboard, this dashboard examines student expenses by university, country, and city. I chose to focus on 2–3 views instead of 4, so that it would be a little less cluttered. I also decided to swap the X and Y axes for my scatter plot. It felt more relevant to know whether a higher cost of living index was correlated with a higher average tuition cost, since students likely would be narrowing down from country to city to university, so this new graph is more helpful to inform decisions about cost tradeoffs for living in more expensive cities.

Findings:

As with the draft dashboard, we can see that the United States is the most expensive country to study abroad in. When recreating the tuition bar graph, I fixed an issue with the university groupings, and after that change it's evident that all of the most expensive universities in this dataset are located in the United States. It also seems that all of the most expensive universities are located on the East Coast. After fixing data mislabeling issues, we can now see that the Netherlands is also in the top 10 most expensive countries in the bottom graph, which did not

display in the draft dashboard because Hong Kong was mislabeled as a country. With the adjusted scatterplot, we can see that there seems to be a pretty strong correlation between a city's cost of living index and their average tuition for a bachelor's degree.

Single-View Dashboard



Description:

This dashboard allows users to explore international student living costs between cities, specifically focusing on which cities are the most expensive for a given country. Users can select a country of interest, or view data for all countries. They can also now take degree level into account, with an option to show tuition only for bachelor's, master's, or doctorate degrees. Additionally, users can filter out results to only see a certain number of data points: if they're only concerned about the top 3 most expensive cities in a given country, then they can choose to display only 3 cities.

Findings:

The data presented in this dashboard makes it even more clear that the United States is the most expensive country to live in based on the data in this dataset, as all cities listed are in the United States. Looking at this graph also reveals some potential limitations about the data. Some of the most expensive cities in the United States (San Jose, Seattle, Los Angeles), are not included in this list of cities, suggesting that either tuition is low enough to balance out living costs (which I doubt), or that they may not be represented in the data sample. I'm curious how

representative this data sample is, as it’s a pretty large dataset but there’s definitely a lot more data for universities located in America, Europe, and Asia, which may be skewing the data results towards those countries and universities.

About Page

About

These dashboards explore data containing tuition and living cost records with information broken down by country, city, university, degree level, and major. I chose to focus on total cost of living (annual rent + tuition + insurance) and bachelor’s degree tuition between different cities, countries, and universities to help narrow down what options look like for students choosing to study abroad.

Findings

Through this data exploration I discovered that the United States is the most country to study abroad in across the board, followed by Singapore, Australia, the UK, Canada, and New Zealand. This was further supported by the fact that the most expensive universities to pursue a Bachelor’s degree are all in the United States (as well as the most expensive cities for total cost of living abroad overall). I also determined that universities situated in a city with a higher cost of living index tend to have more expensive tuition.

Terminology

The Cost of Living Index is used to capture how expensive it is to live in a particular region, with 100 as a baseline representing the cost of living in New York City. A city with a score of 110, for example, is 10% more expensive to live in than New York City.

Links

Data source: [Kaggle Dataset](#)
Draft Google Sheets dashboard: [Google Sheets](#)
Documentation: [Google Doc](#)

Average Annual Cost to Study Abroad by Country

(Rent, Tuition, Insurance)

Country	€
USA	\$71,550
Singapore	\$51,706
Australia	\$51,600
UK	\$45,735
Canada	\$44,153
New Zealand	\$42,000
UAE	\$36,094
Ireland	\$32,180
Israel	\$27,200
Netherlands	\$26,301

Description:

This page gives users a background about the project. It also shows a summary table of the countries with the highest living costs for international students.

Conclusion

Overall, it's evident that the United States is the most expensive place for students to live out of the countries represented in this dataset, and East Coast universities seem to have the highest tuition costs out of all American universities. The scatterplot in the first dashboard also indicates that more expensive universities tend to be situated in more expensive cities on average. I was able to answer all of my initial questions within the scope of this dataset, but I'd be curious to see how this makeup looks with a better representation of universities in all countries. It's possible that the information in this dashboard is more skewed towards the United States, so it would be interesting to see what the distribution of countries and universities looks like for future iterations to determine the level of skew of the data.